

CHAPTER 25

MEENA MAKES A NOISE

'I am back.'

The street which usually sleeps by 10 pm appeared to be awake. Lights were on at my place. Waiting at the gate were my neighbour and colleague Mohana Prasad and his brother-in-law Ramachandra Kurup who also worked with ISRO.

I got out of the car. Prasad came and hugged me as I stood looking at my house, a two-storied structure in white and ochre, the sweat of my brow. Prasad was crying. Retrieving myself from his grip, I walked towards my house. In the drawing room, my daughter Geetha and my two sisters were waiting. As soon as I entered the house, my sisters came to me and held my hands; Geetha stood there, just looking at me. My wife was not to be seen.

'Where's Meena?' I asked.

Geetha pointed towards the flight of stairs, indicating she was upstairs. I took the stairs that led from the drawing room to the first floor where our bedroom was. Why did Meena not wait for me at the gate or in the living room? I wondered. It was almost midnight. She usually went to bed early and was up before the sun. But whenever I came late, she would stay awake for me. Sometimes I would have had dinner with colleagues or friends and she would have been waiting with food for me. She would tuck away the rice in the fridge and go back to bed, with no murmur of protest.

As I entered the room, I saw her on the floor, with no mattress or pillow. The light was switched off, but light from the landing on the first floor